

'It just takes one week to change things'

India's top-ranked singles player **Sumit Nagal** on injuries, comeback and Davis Cup ambitions.

Nihit Sachdeva
nihit.s@thehindu.co.in

Playing the biggest tournaments is every tennis player's dream, but only a handful get to stay there. The rest grind it out on the Challenger Tour, where every match is a battle for survival. India's Sumit Nagal has experienced both worlds. After climbing to a career-high No. 68 in 2024 and competing at the Grand Slams and the Paris Olympics, injuries and a dip in form pushed him back to the Challenger circuit.

In an exclusive interview with *Sportstar*, the World No. 241 discusses his comeback, recent Challenger title, Davis Cup ambitions, Asian Games goals, and life on tour.

How do you see this period between your two latest Challenger Tour titles?

There were a lot of starts and stops because of injuries. It was difficult to get into a rhythm because when you don't play for six to eight weeks, it becomes mentally and physically very tough.

People think that because you've been playing tennis for so long, you can just switch it on and jump back in, but it doesn't work like that. Maybe if I were 6'6" or 6'8" and was just serving big, things would be a little easier. But since I have to play long points, I need to be able to trust my body and my shots, and that took time. Every time I got close to finding that rhythm, another injury or

setback came along. It was very annoying.

The main tour is extremely tough. You're up against the top 60 to 80 players almost every week, and often the top 20. If I'm not at the top of my game, it's a very tough battle because everybody wants the same thing. To compete at that level, you have to find something that gives you an edge and helps you get past them.

Regarding the injury setbacks, have you made any changes to your training regime to address them?

I'm working on my diet and a few other things. There have been some changes, but I will only see the results in the long term, and it's too early for me to say anything right now. Two months ago, I brought a nutritionist on board.

It's an important year, given that there is the Asian Games, which is an Olympic qualifier. How is your